

system. Its online iTunes store offers a large library of online video content, supplementing its dominance over online music sales.

MP3 players score high over mobiles on the following counts:

1. The sound clarity of portable MP3 players is far superior to MP3-enabled mobiles.

2. The battery life of MP3 players can be up to 35 hours, without requiring recharging even for weeks.

3. Some MP3 players come with very high ease of use while searching for the songs or storing and retrieving different album arts.

There are hundreds of MP3 players to choose from, all with their own advantages. Major brands of MP3 players include Apple, Creative Labs, iRiver, Philips, RCA, Samsung, SanDisk, Sony and Toshiba. Brands from smaller companies are also available in the market. MP3 playback has also been incorporated into handheld products like CD players, cell phones and personal digital assistants (PDAs).

Digital MP3 players can be differentiated based on the type of memory used: Flash and hard-disk.

Flash-memory type. Players that use

MP4 players, also known as personal video players, let you view video clipping/video films apart from listening to audio. These score over MP3 players in that they have a larger display screen and can support more formats.

flash memory are extremely sturdy and robust for usage on the move. The reason is these have no moving parts, so you can take them for jogging and your music won't skip. They are the smallest and lightest players, measuring no bigger than a pack of playing cards. Flash memory is available up to 64 GB. In India, you can get up to 16GB only. Most users prefer flash memory-based music players. MP3 players can also double as USB memory sticks. Some may have expansion slots to add more memory via card slots on the player.

However, MP3 players are little expensive in terms of per GB cost compared to hard-disk type.

A good example of MP3 players is Sony's Walkman. Catering to music fanatics with countless CDs at home, Sony's collection of MP3 Walkman is able to shrink your multitude of CDs into just one small device. The flash

memory digital music player range does not only look good, it can accommodate unlimited music transfers or even serve as a data storage device.

Some of the latest Walkman video MP3 players include NWZ-E436F/P and NWZ-E435F/B. Both of these are compact and light-weight, come with FM tuner, support high-quality video playback and have a user-friendly interface for easy operation. The 4GB NWZ-E436F/P is available for Rs 6490, while the 2GB NWZ-E435F/B is priced at Rs 4990.

Hard-disk memory type. These players use mechanical parts and are prone to usage issues when used while skipping or dropped down. They are larger and heavier than flash players. The memory capacity cost per GB is low. In India, you can get up to 160GB hard-disk player. It can store up to 40,000 songs.

Hard-disk MP3 players like Apple iPods lead the portable audio world in terms of storage. The limiting factor is usually price. In general, buy as large a memory as you can afford, but if you only need the space to hold a thousand tunes, there is no reason to spend the extra money for a 40GB player.

Portable MP3 players can be further differentiated based on the formats:

1. *MP3-only audio players.* Branded good-quality MP3-only players are available for Rs 1500 to Rs 6000. Chinese unbranded versions can come for as less as Rs 600-Rs 2000.

2. *MP4 players.* MP4 players, also



Philips personal audio player